

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

SACRIFICE CIRCUS

The Congress in Kerala is full of beans these days, already eyeing a sweep of 100 out of 140 seats in the 2026 assembly poll. On February 28, leader of the Opposition **V.D. Satheeshan** laid out his grand strategy before the party high command in Delhi—a meeting less about tactics and more about keeping the peace, especially with four-time MP **Shashi Tharoor** angling for a bigger role and party general secretary **K.C. Venugopal's** stock rising, courtesy his **Rahul Gandhi** connect. The gathering quickly turned into a spectacle of unity and self-sacrifice. Satheeshan magnanimously declared he had no interest in becoming CM, PCC chief **K. Sudhakaran** echoed the same sentiment. As one leader after another went into renunciation mode, Rahul announced publicly—all is well in the Kerala unit. For now, though, the real math is stark: the Congress currently has just 21 seats in the assembly.

GAFFE AND GUFFAWS

A budget session blooper had the Uttar Pradesh assembly in splits when basic education minister Sandeep Singh of the BJP, wrestling with his written speech, mistakenly referred to a *vidhaayi samaadhikar samiti* (legislative-powered committee) as *vidhaayi samaadhikar shrimati* (... Mrs). Speaker Kunwar Manvendra Singh swiftly corrected him, but the damage was done. Guffaws rippled through the house, with party members too joining in. The Congress wasted no time posting the clip with a stinger: "Teacher recruitment should happen soon so ministers can also learn to read and write." Even within the BJP, whispers of concern surfaced—Sandeep, grandson of ex-Uttar Pradesh CM Kalyan Singh, cannot afford to send gift-wrapped gaffes for the Opposition.



Backhanded Altruism?



The Shiv Sena (UBT), still smarting from its split with the BJP, found itself in the odd position of applauding its former foe. In an unexpected twist, party mouthpiece *Saamana* heaped praise on Maharashtra CM **Devendra Fadnavis** for vetoing the 16 ministerial recommendations for personal staff appointments—apparently because they were "fixers". The enthusiasm, however, isn't entirely altruistic. Of the 16 rejected names, a delightful 12 belonged to ministers from Eknath Shinde's Shiv Sena. Coincidence? Unlikely.

OUT OF STEP



Gujarat's AAP legislator **Chaitar Vasava**'s impromptu jig at a Surat wedding became an instant viral sensation—not for his moves, but for his dance partner. The tribal leader from Chhotaudepur was caught on camera grooving alongside Budhiyo, a known bootlegger, setting off a political frenzy. AAP cried foul, claiming Budhiyo was actually a BJP man, fuelling whispers about Vasava's future in a party still reeling from its Delhi debacle. But as the dust settled, it turned out to be little more than a storm in a teacup. Vasava insisted he had no clue who Budhiyo was—the man had simply joined steps with him. A classic case of wrong place, wrong time...or in this case, wrong dance partner.

TRICKY DOUBLE ROLE

Prashant Kishor's political tightrope act just hit a wobble. His grand pronouncement on Thanthi TV—that actor Vijay's fledgling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) will contest solo in 2026 (without the AIADMK) has left the political rookie blindsided. This, despite Kishor waxing eloquent at TVK's anniversary event, calling the party "Tamil Nadu's dream" and pledging to steer it to victory. Vijay, however, is unimpressed. On March 2, TVK issued a crisp reminder that only designated voices speak for the party. Meanwhile, Kishor's outfit, Simple Sense, is busy running AIADMK's digital campaign, making his dual role as strategist and aspiring kingmaker a tricky balancing act—especially in TN, where the audience knows a plot twist when it sees one.



ANI

Kaushik Deka with Jeemon Jacob, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Jumana Shah, Avaneesh Mishra and Amarnath K. Menon